



PHOTO BY CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Skills Push

The skill development ministry plans to partner with the UGC to improve the employability of undergraduates

BY SUDESHNA MITRA

► **THE CENTRAL GOVERNMENT**, looking to address the widening skills gap in the Indian workforce, is considering partnering with the University Grants Commission (UGC) to address this pressing need.

Jayant Chaudhary, Minister of State for Skill Development and Entrepreneurship, said recently that his ministry is in talks with the UGC to upskill undergraduates. “We are in talks with UGC to upskill undergraduates to build a strong domestic workforce,” he said at the *Business Today* India@100 Summit.

The question of employment and

THE PLAN
Emerging technology courses like AI, data analytics, and cybersecurity will be offered to students

skilling featured heavily in the General Elections earlier this year and was echoed in the Union Budget 2024-25 that was presented in the polls’ aftermath on July 23.

Explaining the plan, UGC Chairman M. Jagadesh Kumar says his organisation will offer emerging technology courses like artificial intelligence (AI), data analytics, and cybersecurity, ensuring students acquire industry-relevant skills in e-commerce, digital finance, digital marketing, etc. India has vast potential, as there are about 43 million students, of whom 79% are pursuing graduation, he adds.

“So, we want to incorporate skill-based courses within the degree programmes and expect the outcome to manifest tangibly within the next two to three years, while substantial outcomes are expected to be achieved over the next five years,” Kumar says. The UGC could

UGC PLANS TO BUILD ON EXISTING INITIATIVES SUCH AS THE NEP

build upon existing initiatives such as the National Education Policy, designed to incorporate vocational training in the pre-school to Class 12 curricula.

Welcoming the move, Pankaj Bansal, Founder of human resources firm PeopleStrong, says there has been notable improvement in the employability of youth, from just 34% of graduates in 2014 to 52%. “Today, besides hard skills, companies seek soft skills like problem-solving, communication, and adaptability for navigating the complexities of the workplace. Such government initiatives may aid this, building a strong employment landscape.” **BT**

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